

ONE COMMANDMENT

How Four Persian Decrees Point to the Messiah

A Continuous Jubilee Calendar Study

*“And they builded, and finished it, according to the commandment of the God of Israel, and according to the commandment of Cyrus, and Darius, and Artaxerxes king of Persia.” —
Ezra 6:14 (KJV)*

1. A Clock With a Starting Line

Picture an old man on his knees in Babylon. His name is Daniel. He was carried away from Jerusalem as a young man, and now, nearly seventy years later, he is reading the scroll of the prophet Jeremiah. There he finds the promise he has been waiting for: God would “accomplish seventy years in the desolations of Jerusalem” (Daniel 9:2). The seventy years are almost over.

So Daniel prays. He confesses that Israel broke “the law of Moses” (Daniel 9:11, 13), and he begs God to look on His ruined city: “behold our desolations, and the city which is called by thy name” (Daniel 9:18).

While he is still praying, the angel Gabriel arrives with an answer far bigger than Daniel asked for: “Seventy weeks are determined upon thy people and upon thy holy city” (Daniel 9:24). Then he gives the schedule: “from the going forth of the commandment to restore and to build Jerusalem unto the Messiah the Prince shall be seven weeks, and threescore and two weeks” (Daniel 9:25).

Every clock needs a starting line, and Gabriel named this one: a commandment to restore and build Jerusalem. But before we look for that commandment, we need to understand the words Gabriel chose, because Daniel understood them in a way most readers today miss.

2. Gabriel Speaks Daniel’s Language

The word “weeks” here means “sevens.” Gabriel is not talking about seven-day weeks. He is talking about weeks of *years*, and every faithful Israelite knew exactly what those were, because God built them into the law of Moses.

Every seventh year, the land was to rest: “in the seventh year shall be a sabbath of rest unto the land” (Leviticus 25:4). So Israel counted its years in sevens: year 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, then 7, the sabbath year. Then 1 through 7 again, and again. A week of years was never just any seven years in a row. It always ran from year 1 to year 7 of that sabbath cycle.

Then came the Jubilee: “thou shalt number seven sabbaths of years unto thee, seven times seven years; and the space of the seven sabbaths of years shall be unto thee forty and nine years” (Leviticus 25:8). Seven weeks of years is one full Jubilee cycle.

Now listen again to Gabriel: “seven weeks, and threescore and two weeks.” His very first number is *seven weeks*, the exact measure of a Jubilee cycle, in the language of Leviticus 25. Daniel had just confessed breaking the law of Moses, the law that commanded those sabbath years and Jubilees. He would have heard

it at once: this countdown is measured in the same sevens God gave Israel's calendar. A count in Jubilee cycles begins where a Jubilee cycle begins. The commandment to look for would come in a Jubilee year, year 1 of a new cycle.

And the whole prophecy fits the same pattern. Seventy weeks of years is 490 years, which is exactly ten Jubilee cycles. On the Continuous Jubilee Calendar, 457 BC is Cycle 21, Year 1, a Jubilee year, and AD 34 is Cycle 31, Year 1, the next Jubilee ten cycles later. (*See In Due Time and Chapter 1.*)

The Persian kings who ruled after Babylon did not issue one order about Jerusalem. They issued four. This paper follows the story the way Scripture tells it, one king at a time. Watch how each step builds on the one before, until the commandment is complete, in a Jubilee year, and the clock begins to run toward the cross.

3. The Broken City

In 586 BC, the armies of Babylon came to Jerusalem for the last time. "They burnt the house of God, and brake down the wall of Jerusalem, and burnt all the palaces thereof with fire" (2 Chronicles 36:19). The Temple was gone, the walls were rubble, and the people were marched away to Babylon.

God had warned them. If Israel refused to give the land its sabbath rest, He would scatter them, and "then shall the land enjoy her sabbaths" (Leviticus 26:34). And so it did. The exile lasted "until the land had enjoyed her sabbaths: for as long as she lay desolate she kept sabbath, to fulfil threescore and ten years" (2 Chronicles 36:21). Even while no one in Israel was counting, God was.

When the seventy years ran out, three things lay broken. The *house* of God was destroyed. The *people* had lost their worship and the rule of God's law. And the *city*, with its streets, gates, and walls, lay in ruins. Scripture shows God restoring all three, one king at a time.

4. Cyrus: The Foundation (538 BC)

In 539 BC, Babylon fell to the Medes and Persians in a single night (Daniel 5:30-31). The new ruler was Cyrus, king of Persia, and the prophet Isaiah had named him more than a century before he was born. God called Cyrus "my shepherd," who would say "to Jerusalem, Thou shalt be built; and to the temple, Thy foundation shall be laid" (Isaiah 44:28). "He shall build my city, and he shall let go my captives" (Isaiah 45:13).

In his first year, Cyrus did exactly that: “The LORD God of heaven... hath charged me to build him an house at Jerusalem” (Ezra 1:2). Any of God’s people who wished could go home and build.

About fifty thousand made the journey (Ezra 2:64-65). In the seventh month they built the altar and began the sacrifices again (Ezra 3:1-6). In the second year they laid the Temple’s foundation. The people “shouted with a great shout,” but the old men who remembered Solomon’s Temple “wept with a loud voice,” so that no one could tell the shouts of joy from the weeping (Ezra 3:11-13).

Isaiah’s words came true: the captives went free, the foundation was laid, and homes rose in Jerusalem again. But the house was not finished, and the city had no walls. The commandment had begun, but it was not complete.

5. The Long Silence (536-520 BC)

Then everything stopped. The neighboring peoples “weakened the hands of the people of Judah, and troubled them in building, and hired counsellors against them, to frustrate their purpose, all the days of Cyrus king of Persia, even until the reign of Darius” (Ezra 4:4-5). For about sixteen years, the Temple site sat half-built.

The people grew discouraged and turned to their own affairs. “This people say, The time is not come, the time that the LORD’s house should be built,” God said through the prophet Haggai. “Is it time for you, O ye, to dwell in your cieled houses, and this house lie waste?” (Haggai 1:2, 4). The people had homes. God’s house lay waste.

6. Darius: The House Finished (520-515 BC)

In the second year of King Darius, God sent the prophets Haggai and Zechariah to stir the people up (Ezra 5:1), and the building began again.

The local governor, Tattenai, challenged them: “Who hath commanded you to build this house?” (Ezra 5:3). The Jews answered that Cyrus had. So Darius had the royal archives searched, and in the palace at Achmetha a scroll was found with Cyrus’s decree: “Let the house be builded” (Ezra 6:2-3).

Darius did not just allow the work. He commanded it. “Let the work of this house of God alone,” he ordered, and he paid for it from the king’s own taxes (Ezra 6:7-8). The Temple was finished “on the third day of the month Adar, which was in the sixth year of the reign of Darius the king” (Ezra 6:15), in 515 BC. The people

dedicated it with joy, set the priests in their divisions (Ezra 6:18), and kept the Passover (Ezra 6:19-22).

Right in the middle of this story, Scripture says something remarkable. The Temple was finished “according to the commandment of the God of Israel, and according to the commandment of Cyrus, and Darius, and Artaxerxes king of Persia” (Ezra 6:14). Artaxerxes had not even come to the throne yet. Why is his name here? Scripture is telling us to keep reading. The commandment is not finished.

7. Artaxerxes and Ezra: The City Restored (457 BC)

Nearly sixty years later, in “the seventh year of Artaxerxes the king” (Ezra 7:7), Ezra enters the story. He was a priest and “a ready scribe in the law of Moses” (Ezra 7:6), who “had prepared his heart to seek the law of the LORD, and to do it, and to teach in Israel statutes and judgments” (Ezra 7:10).

Artaxerxes gave Ezra a decree (Ezra 7:12-26) that did four things:

- **It sent the people and their ministers.** Any of Israel, “and of his priests and Levites,” could go with Ezra (7:13). When Ezra found no Levites among his company, he sent for them before setting out (Ezra 8:15-20).
- **It supplied the worship.** Silver and gold were given to buy “bullocks, rams, lambs... and offer them upon the altar” (7:17), with vessels “for the service of the house of thy God” (7:19), and the royal treasuries were told to provide whatever more was needed (7:21-22).
- **It protected the Temple’s servants.** No tax could be laid on the priests, Levites, singers, porters, or Temple servants (7:24).
- **It restored God’s law as the law of the land.** Ezra was to “set magistrates and judges, which may judge all the people,” and teach God’s law to those who did not know it. Anyone who would not obey “the law of thy God, and the law of the king” would face judgment, “whether it be unto death, or to banishment, or to confiscation of goods, or to imprisonment” (7:25-26).

The Temple, already finished, was now fully supplied, staffed, and protected. And for the first time since the exile, Jerusalem was a city governed by God’s law, with its own judges and the power to enforce justice. That is what “restore” means.

Ezra saw the hand of God in it: “Blessed be the LORD God of our fathers, which hath put such a thing as this in the king’s heart, to beautify the house of the LORD which is in Jerusalem” (Ezra 7:27). He set out on the first day of the first month and arrived four months later, “according to the good hand of his God upon him” (Ezra 7:9).

And notice the year. On the Continuous Jubilee Calendar, 457 BC is Cycle 21, Year 1, a Jubilee. The Jubilee law said, “ye shall return every man unto his possession” (Leviticus 25:10). In 457 BC, God’s people were sent home to their land, restored to their worship, and returned to the rule of His law. Even the words agree: the Hebrew word Gabriel used for “restore” in Daniel 9:25 comes from the same root as the Jubilee’s “return” in Leviticus 25:10.

8. Troublous Times

With the city restored to its own government, the people began to rebuild its walls. Their enemies noticed at once and wrote to Artaxerxes: “Be it known unto the king, that the Jews which came up from thee to us are come unto Jerusalem, building the rebellious and the bad city, and have set up the walls thereof, and joined the foundations” (Ezra 4:12). “The Jews which came up from thee” were the people who had come with the king’s permission, and they were already building the city and its walls.

The letter warned that a walled Jerusalem would stop paying taxes. So the king ordered the work stopped, but he chose his words carefully: “Give ye now commandment to cause these men to cease, and that this city be not builded, *until another commandment shall be given from me*” (Ezra 4:21). He did not cancel the restoration. He paused it, and kept the right to restart it.

The enemies went straight to Jerusalem “and made them to cease by force and power” (Ezra 4:23). What had been built was torn down again.

This fits Gabriel’s words exactly: “the street shall be built again, and the wall, even in troublous times” (Daniel 9:25). *(Ezra 4 groups these letters by topic rather than in strict time order, but “the Jews which came up from thee” fits the people who came with Ezra. Where the KJV reads “wall” in Daniel 9:25, some translations read “moat,” another part of a city’s defenses.)*

9. Nehemiah: The Wall in Fifty-Two Days (444 BC)

Thirteen years after Ezra’s journey, Nehemiah was serving in the Persian palace as the king’s cupbearer. Visitors came from Judah, and their news broke his heart: “the wall of Jerusalem also is broken down, and the gates thereof are burned with fire” (Nehemiah 1:3). The Babylonians had burned the gates 140 years earlier. This was fresh news: the walls that had been rising were torn down again.

He wept, fasted, and prayed. Then, in the month Nisan, in “the twentieth year of Artaxerxes the king” (Nehemiah 2:1), the king noticed his sad face. Nehemiah

asked to be sent to rebuild the city, with letters to the governors and “a letter unto Asaph the keeper of the king’s forest, that he may give me timber to make beams for the gates... and for the wall of the city” (Nehemiah 2:7-8).

“And the king granted me,” Nehemiah wrote, “according to the good hand of my God upon me” (Nehemiah 2:8), almost the same words Ezra used thirteen years earlier. The same king, the same good hand of God, the same restoration, now resumed. The “another commandment” Artaxerxes had promised had come.

Sanballat and Tobiah mocked and threatened the builders (Nehemiah 4:1-8), so the people built with weapons ready: “every one with one of his hands wrought in the work, and with the other hand held a weapon” (Nehemiah 4:17). Troublous times, just as Gabriel said.

And yet, “the wall was finished in the twenty and fifth day of the month Elul, in fifty and two days” (Nehemiah 6:15). Even their enemies “perceived that this work was wrought of our God” (Nehemiah 6:16). The gates were hung (Nehemiah 7:1). Then all the people gathered, and Ezra read the law of God aloud from morning until midday (Nehemiah 8:1-8). Ezra and Nehemiah stood together, the law and the wall, the two halves of one restoration.

10. One Commandment

- **Cyrus** laid the foundation and let the captives go home.
- **Darius** finished the house.
- **Artaxerxes**, through Ezra, restored the worship, the priesthood’s support, and the rule of God’s law, and the city began to rise.
- **The same Artaxerxes**, through Nehemiah, gave the letters that let the walls and gates be finished.

Scripture does not treat these as four competing decrees. It treats them as one commandment given in stages: “according to the commandment of Cyrus, and Darius, and Artaxerxes king of Persia” (Ezra 6:14). The word “commandment” there is singular, just as Gabriel spoke of “the going forth of the commandment” (Daniel 9:25).

Each stage builds on the one before. Darius searched for Cyrus’s decree and confirmed it. Artaxerxes provided for “the house of thy God” that Darius had finished. Nehemiah’s letters carried forward the work Artaxerxes had already begun, as the king himself had said they would.

So when did the commandment fully “go forth”? Not when the foundation was laid, and not when the house was finished. Jerusalem was not truly *restored* until

its worship was supplied and its people were living again under God's law, with the right to govern themselves and to rebuild. That happened in 457 BC. Nehemiah's letters did not start something new. They completed what 457 BC had set in motion.

The commandment went forth in a Jubilee year, just as Gabriel's "seven weeks" had signaled.

11. Testing Every Decree Against the Clock

Gabriel said there would be sixty-nine weeks, or 483 years, "unto the Messiah the Prince." Count 483 years from each decree:

- **Cyrus, 538 BC → 55 BC.** Nothing happens connected to the Messiah.
- **Darius, 520 BC → 37 BC.** Herod the Great captures Jerusalem, the king who later tried to kill the infant Jesus.
- **Artaxerxes to Ezra, 457 BC → AD 27.** Jesus is baptized and anointed with the Holy Spirit (Luke 3:21-22). He begins His ministry saying, "The time is fulfilled" (Mark 1:15).
- **Artaxerxes to Nehemiah, 444 BC → AD 40.** Nothing happens connected to the Messiah.

(There is no year zero between BC and AD. That is why 457 BC plus 483 years lands on AD 27, not AD 26.)

Only one decree reaches the Messiah: 457 BC.

Some teachers start from Nehemiah in 444 BC. To make it work, they shorten every year to 360 days, a "prophetic year" that Scripture never uses for these 483 years. Even then, their count reaches AD 33, and they must place Daniel's seventieth week far in the future, with a gap of almost two thousand years in the middle of the prophecy. Gabriel described no gap. (*See Daniel 9: The 360-Day Year.*)

Counted in ordinary years, from the decree that actually restored Jerusalem, the prophecy lands on the Messiah to the year. (*Some scholars date Artaxerxes' seventh year to 458 BC, depending on how his reign is counted. The CJC uses 457 BC, and that is the year the arithmetic confirms.*)

12. The Midst of the Week

Gabriel continued: “And after threescore and two weeks shall Messiah be cut off, but not for himself... and in the midst of the week he shall cause the sacrifice and the oblation to cease” (Daniel 9:26-27).

Remember how Israel counted its weeks of years: always 1 through 7. On the Continuous Jubilee Calendar, AD 27, the year of Jesus’ anointing, is Cycle 30, Year 43, which is year 1 of a new week of years. So the seventieth week runs like this:

- **Year 1 — AD 27:** Jesus is anointed and begins His ministry.
- **Years 2 and 3 — AD 28 and 29:** He teaches, heals, and keeps the Passovers John records (John 2:13; 6:4).
- **Year 4 — AD 30:** the middle of the week. Jesus is crucified on Friday, April 7, AD 30, at the third Passover John records (John 11:55). Year 4 is the exact center of a 1-to-7 week.
- **Years 5, 6, and 7 — AD 31 to 33:** the gospel is preached in Jerusalem and Judea. AD 33 is a sabbath year, and the seventy weeks run out.
- **Then AD 34 — Cycle 31, Year 1:** the next Jubilee begins, exactly ten cycles after 457 BC. The believers “that were scattered abroad went every where preaching the word” (Acts 8:4), and liberty spreads to the nations.

At the moment Jesus died, “the veil of the temple was rent in twain from the top to the bottom” (Matthew 27:51). The sacrifices went on in the Temple for another forty years, but their purpose had ended. The Lamb of God had come, “in the midst of the week,” exactly as Gabriel said.

This is the test no other decree can pass. Only 457 BC gives seventy continuous weeks, starting in a Jubilee year, reaching the Messiah’s anointing at the start of the seventieth week, placing the cross in its middle year, and ending ten full Jubilee cycles later. Cyrus and Darius never reach the Messiah. Nehemiah’s date needs shortened years and a gap. 457 BC needs nothing added and nothing taken away. (*See Decree to Cross, Crucifixion, and In Due Time.*)

13. The Word That Kept Its Time

Daniel prayed for a ruined city. God answered with a Messiah and a calendar.

Over the next century, God moved the hearts of three Persian kings. Cyrus laid the foundation. Darius finished the house. Artaxerxes restored the worship and the law, and then gave the letters that raised the walls. Through discouragement,

delays, threats, and walls torn down, the work went on, “according to the good hand of my God upon me.”

Scripture calls it one commandment. It went forth in a Jubilee year. And from that year, the clock God built into the law of Moses counted forward, seven years at a time, to a baptism by the Jordan, a cross outside Jerusalem, and a message of liberty carried to the ends of the earth.

“The time is fulfilled,” Jesus said. It was, to the year.

Sources and References

Scripture: all quotations are from the King James Version (KJV).

Continuous Jubilee Calendar: Welsh, Chip. *The CJC Research Kit*, Version 12.20, September 24, 2026, and the CJC papers *Chapter 1, Decree to Cross, Crucifixion, In Due Time*, and *Daniel 9: The 360-Day Year*, available at <https://github.com/Greysmokez/Continuous-Jubilee-Calendar> and <https://greysmokez.github.io/CJC-Website/>